

THE GARAMUT

A MESSAGE SENDER



Ps Barry's *Reflections on:* **PRAYER,** **PROCLAMATION and** **PERSONAL PROGRESS**

Bethel Global Missions
No.41. 21st November 022



CHARACTER

"What did you go out into the wilderness to see"? Luke 7:24

• **OUR FOCUS:**

- WHAT WE MIGHT EXPECT TO SEE IN THE LIFE OF TODAY'S FOLLOWER OF CHRIST AND CHRISTIAN LEADERSHIP.
- Luke 7:24-27
- 24 When the messengers of John had departed, He began to speak to the multitudes concerning John: **"What did you go out into the wilderness to see?"**
- A reed shaken by the wind?
- 25 **But what did you go out to see?** A man clothed in soft garments? Indeed those who are gorgeously apparelled and live in luxury are in kings' courts. 26 **But what did you go out to see?** A prophet? Yes, I say to you, and more than a prophet. 27 This is he of whom it is written: 'Behold, I send My messenger before Your face, Who will prepare Your way before You.' NKJV

WHAT YE WENT OUT TO SEE?

- JESUS ASKED THIS QUESTION TO THE CROWD OF CONCERNING JOHN THE BAPTIST as they went out to meet him in the wilderness / desert.
Matthew 3:1 In those days John the Baptist came into the wilderness of Judea proclaiming, NET (Desert of Judea) NIV
- ◆ In the days of Jesus, what were the expectations of the crowd about this man they called John the Baptist, a man whose clothing was camel's hair with a leather belt around his waist, and his diet consisted of locusts and wild honey.
Matthew 3:4-5 -Now John wore clothing made from camel's hair with a leather belt around his waist, and his diet consisted of locusts and wild honey. - 5 Then people from Jerusalem, as well as all Judea and all the region around the Jordan, were going out to him, NET
- ◆ What were their expectations regarding John the Baptist?
- ◆ What **kind of person** did they think this man would be like?
- ◆ What was it about him that crowds of people came out to follow him? What was it that attracted people to him?

■ JESUS ASKED; WHAT WERE YOU EXPECTING TO SEE - IN JOHN?

1. **A reed swayed by the wind?**
 - ◆ Were you expecting to see a person who is easily swayed from one opinion to another – tossed to-and-fro like a reed blown in the wind?
2. **Someone dressed in fine clothes?**
 - ◆ Or were you expecting to see someone in expensive clothes, dressed like a prince?
3. **A strange and different person living in the desert.**
 - ◆ Or was he just another one of those strange persons who claimed to be a prophet but many thought to be mad.

LESSONS, RELEVANCE & APPLICATION

- ◆ What are the lessons for us from this passage?
- ◆ How might it be relevant for us today?
- ◆ The statement that Jesus asked – **"what ye went out to see"** – is very relevant and applicable for us today.
- **WHAT is it that we are expecting to see in the lives of Christ's followers and in leaders today?**
 - ◆ Certainly, it is something more than strict compliance to contemporary dress codes, or location (where one comes from).
 - ◆ It needs to be more than just **charisma, attractiveness and appeal**.

- ♦ It also has to be more than someone who often changes from one opinion to another opinion and changing directions. *(Like a reed blown in the wind)*.
- ♦ Surely we should be expecting to see someone who is definite, resolute and unchanging in relation to things that are clearly defined in God's Word.
- ♦ IT HAS TO BE SOMEONE WITH CHARACTER AND SUBSTANCE TO THEIR LIFESTYLE AND PROFESSION.

APPLICATION

- Do we sometimes compromise on our standards and opinions we have held for a long time; or tend to follow after those that have charisma, appeal attractiveness in ministry instead of those showing substance, integrity, character?
- Do we ever ask the question what is the reason behind why some people, and leaders are always changing their minds, moving from one opinion to another rather than standing firm to those matters that are clearly stated and firmly set by God in the Bible?
- ♦ IS IT BECAUSE THEY ARE UNSTABLE (James 1:8) - OR STILL BABES. Hebrews 5:12 - NLT - 1 Corinthians 3:2 KJV -

JOHN'S GREATNESS:

Those principle points should be noted.

- ♦ It did not come from the location he came from, nor in the way he dressed or what he ate.

It came from:

1. The call of God on his life (to a prophet),
2. His appointed time and destiny that had been given to him fulfil (the ushering in the coming ministry of Jesus).
3. The unchanging and demanding substance of the message that he preached.
4. The kind of person he was – his character.

Here are some questions that we can ask ourselves in relation to other EXPECTATIONS that we might have about other things in life.

Example:

1. What are we expecting to find attracted to in a Christian Leader? *Or are we more drawn to those with Charisma, influence, and dynastism? Or drawn to something else – like character?*
2. What are we expecting to find in a local church? *Is it attractiveness, appeal, or Godly substance?*
3. What are our expectations in relation to the message preached? *Are we more drawn towards presentation, style, skill elegance; than we are towards substance and content that reflects lasting truths of God's Word?*
4. What kind of person do you want to be – what expectations do you have for your own life? *Are they to be more acceptable, recognised and popular – or to be someone who desires integrity, honesty and displays Godly character?*
5. What are our expectation of God? Are they realistic and true to the Scripture? *Or are they wrongly based on the assumption that he is only there to respond to our needs?*
6. What kind of things are you looking for in a life's partner (to marry)? What are you first attracted to? *Is it outward beauty / handsomeness etc, popularity, skilfulness etc?* What about the inner quality of a person, the kind they are known for – their Character?
7. What are our expectations of a person of differing ethnic and cultural or background? *Nathanael wrongly judged about Jesus simply on the basis of his prejudice of all people based on where they were born (Nazareth) "Can anything good come from Nazareth?" John 1:45 - 46 NLT*
8. May we base our expectations on what God's Word says and not on the speculative ideas and thoughts, that are so popularly promoted today even within the church.
9. Let us stick closely to the Biblical content and substance (the core values) of the message (Gospel) that was preached, by Christ and his Apostles and not misinterpreted speculations of some modern preachers.

- ARE OUR EXPECTATIONS MORE CONTEMPORARY AND CULTURAL AND THAT HAVE NOT REAL LASTING VALUE FOR US OR GOD.
- ARE WE EXPECTING TO SEE CHARACTER, SUBSTANCE, INTEGRITY GODLINESS AMONGST GOD'S PEOPLE?
- Is there preparedness in us to SHUN THE EMPTINESS OF CONTEMPORARY CULTURE, WISDOM THE ELEVATION OF MAN AND THE POMOTION OF SELF?

Amen

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